

Sanskrit, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

Sanskrit, like Latin, is not learned for conversation. It is learned to read, to hear how much of the world’s vocabulary was assembled, and — the reason it sits in this series — because it is a **taproot**: the classical ancestor of Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali, whose every “hello” and “thank you” is a worn-down form of a Sanskrit word you will meet here in its full shape. And Sanskrit is at the same time a *sister* of Latin, Greek, and English — so its roots reach west (to *thee*, to Greek *eu-*, to *come*, to *no*) as surely as they reach east. Learning it ties the two halves of this curriculum together.

Sanskrit is classically written in **Devanagari**, the script you may already know from Hindi. This book teaches the reading *inside* the word lessons, with attention to the features Sanskrit needs even from a Devanagari reader — the *visarga* (ḥ), the vocalic ṛ, the conjuncts, and the *sandhi* that fuses words at their seams. (A reader new to the script learns it here from scratch; one who knows it skims the notes.)

We use standard **IAST** transliteration (the dotted ṛ, ḥ, ś, and macrons) alongside the Devanagari, and trace roots back toward Proto-Indo-European where the trail is clear — every form supplied in full. When Sir William Jones told the Asiatic Society in 1786 that Sanskrit bore to Latin and Greek “a stronger affinity... than could possibly have been produced by accident,” he launched the whole science of comparative linguistics; this book is, in miniature, a tour of the words he meant.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Sanskrit out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your*

turn are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Sanskrit greetings — and why they are the other **taproot** of this whole curriculum. Every “thank you” and “hello” in the Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali tracks points back here; and Sanskrit is at the same time a *sister* of Latin, Greek, and English, so its words reach west as well as east. Each lesson introduces the letters and the Sanskrit-specific reading its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/SA-C01-*.md.*

1.1 नमस्ते (*namaste*) — “I bow to you”

The letters in this word

Devanagari runs **left to right** under a top line; every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न *na*, म *ma*, ते *te* (त + the *e*-sign े). A *hasanta* under स् strips its vowel so it joins the next: स् + त → स्त. Read नमस्ते as *na · ma · s · te*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्ते = *namas* (“a bow, obeisance”) + *te* (“to you”) — literally “**a bow to you.**” This is the *original*: the word every Indo-Aryan track in this curriculum descends from — Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, Bengali all say a worn form of it. *Namas* comes from the root $\sqrt{nam}$ “to bend, bow,” from Proto-Indo-European **nem-* “to allot, take.” And *te* “to you” is a family heirloom: the same Indo-European pronoun behind Latin *tē*, Greek *se*, and archaic English **thee**. Say *namas-te* and you are speaking a word Cicero and Chaucer would each have half-recognised.

Why it's said this way

Palms pressed together (the gesture is *añjali*), a slight bow: the hands and the word say the same thing. *Namaste* greets the person before you as worthy of a bow — hello, and, when parting, goodbye. It is the greeting Sanskrit gave to half of South Asia.

1.2 नमस्कारः (*namaskārah*) — the fuller form**The letters in this word**

New: का *kā* (क + the ā-sign ा), र *ra*, and the **visarga** ः — a soft breathed “h” at a word’s end, written as two dots. नमस्कारः = *namaskārah*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कारः = *namas* (“a bow”) + *kāra* (“the making, the doing,” from the root *√kr* “to do/make”). So *namaskāra* is “the **making** of a bow” — an act, where *namaste* is an address. That root *√kr* “to do” is one of the most productive in Sanskrit (it gives *karma*, “a thing done”); it is the Indo-European **kwer-* and a distant cousin of English *-ory/-ure* words of making. The final **visarga** *-ah* is the mark of the masculine singular — your first case-ending.

Grammar Lens

Namaste and *namaskāra* share the same first half, *namas*, but end differently because they *do* different grammatical jobs — one takes a pronoun (*te* “to you”), the other builds a noun (*-kāra* “the making of”). Sanskrit words are transparently assembled from roots and endings like this; once you see the seams, long words stop being frightening.

1.3 धन्यवादः (*dhanyavādaḥ*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ध *dha* (breathy *d*), व *va*, द *da*, and the conjunct न्य (न + य *ya*).
With the visarga again, read धन्यवादः as *dha · nya · vā · daḥ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवादः = *dhanya* (“worthy, deserving,” from *dhana* “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a speaking, a statement,” from the root *√vad* “to speak”). Literally “a saying of “you are worthy.”” This is the *source* of the thanks you met to the east — Hindi *dhanyavād*, Marathi and Punjabi likewise — here in its full, un-worn Sanskrit shape, visarga and all.

1.4 स्वागतम् (*svāgatam*) — “welcome”

The letters in this word

New: the conjunct स्व (स् + व *va*) = *sva*, ग *ga*, and the *halant* म् *m* closing the word with no vowel. Read स्वागतम् as *svā · ga · tam*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

स्वागतम् = *su* (“well, good”) + *āgata* (“come,” from *ā* “toward” + the root *√gam* “to go/come”) — “**well come**,” which is exactly what English *welcome* means too. Two deep Indo-European threads surface here:

- *su*- “good” is the twin of **Greek eu-** — the *eu* of *euphoria*, *eulogy*, *euphemism*. Sanskrit *su-gata* and Greek *eu-* are the same prefix.
- the root *√gam* “to go/come” is the Indo-European **gʷem-* — the very root of English **come** (and of Latin *venire*, hence *venue*, *con-vene*).

So *svāgatam* and *welcome* are not just parallel ideas but partly *cognate* ones.

1.5 आम् / न (*ām* / *na*) — “yes” and “no”

The letters in this word

New: आ — the **independent** vowel ā (the shape for a word-initial vowel) — closed by the halant म् *m*: आम् *ām*. And न *na*, a single consonant with its built-in “a.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आम् (*ām*, “yes”) and न (*na*, “no, not”). That *na* is a word you have already met wearing other clothes: it is Proto-Indo-European **ne* “not,” **the same negative** as the Latin *nōn* of the last track, as English **no**, **not**, **none**, as German *nein*, and as Hindi *nahīn*. Of all the words in this book, *na* may be the one that reaches furthest unchanged: one tiny syllable spoken, in some form, from Iceland to India for five thousand years.

Why it’s said this way

Classical Sanskrit, like Latin, leans on more than a bare “yes”: one often answers by echoing the verb, or with *ām*, *evam* (“so it is”), or *bāḍham* (“certainly”). The blunt yes/no habit of English is not universal — these old languages preferred to *say what they meant*.

1.6 Recap

Sanskrit		Meaning
नमस्ते	<i>namaste</i>	hello (“a bow to you”)
नमस्कारः	<i>namaskāraḥ</i>	hello (“the making of a bow”)
धन्यवादः	<i>dhanyavādaḥ</i>	thank you
स्वागतम्	<i>svāgatam</i>	welcome (“well come”)
आम् / न	<i>ām</i> / <i>na</i>	yes / no

Sanskrit is the eastern taproot: *namas*, *dhanya-vāda*, and the bow that survives, worn smooth, as every Indo-Aryan hello and thank-you. But look which way its roots also point — *te* “to you” toward English *thee*, *su-* “good” toward Greek *eu-*, *√gam* toward *come*, *na* toward *no* and Latin *nōn*. When Sir William Jones noticed in 1786 that Sanskrit, Latin, and Greek were kin, *these* are the kinds of words he meant. Next chapter: introducing yourself

— *mama nāma...* (“my name...”) — and Sanskrit’s astonishing verb, which marks person, number, *and* how many are speaking.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — and, since this is Sanskrit, each atom is the *ancestor* of words across both Europe and modern India:

मम नाम अरुणः अस्ति। (mama nāma Aruṇaḥ asti — “My name is Arun.”)
तव नाम किम्? (tava nāma kim — “What is your name?”)

Practice lessons: lessons/SA-C02-.md.*

2.1 नाम (*nāma*) — “name,” the source of a word half the world shares

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाम (*nāma*, “name”) is from the stem *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃nómn̥*. This is not a borrowing but the *ancestor*: English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), Greek *onoma*, and, worn down, Hindi *nām*, Bengali *nām*. Saying *nāma*, you stand near the headwaters of a word that flowed to both Europe and modern India.

2.2 मम (*mama*) — “my,” the ancestor of *me* and *my*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मम (*mama*, “my, of me”) is the genitive of अहम् (*aham*, “I”), on the first-person root *ma-*, PIE **me-* — the source of English **me**, **my**, **mine**, Latin *meus*, and Hindi *merā*. Sanskrit *mama* and English *my* are the same ancient word, one still in its old form.

2.3 अस्ति (*asti*) — “is,” the ancestor of *is* and *est*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अस्ति (*asti*, “is”) is the third person of the root अस् (*as-*, “to be”), PIE **h₁es-* — the source of English **is**, Latin *est*, Greek *esti*, and Hindi *hai* (from *asti* directly). Unlike its Dravidian neighbours (Tamil and Bengali drop “is”), Sanskrit *keeps* an explicit copula — the word Europe kept too.

2.4 मम नाम ...अस्ति — “my name is...”

मम (my) + नाम (name) + name + अस्ति (is) = “my name is...” The verb comes **last**.

Grammar Lens

Sanskrit keeps the “is.” Tamil says only *en peyar Arun*, Bengali *āmār nām Arun* — both dropping the verb. Sanskrit says *mama nāma ...asti*, with an explicit *asti* — the Indo-European way, kept by Latin and English too.

2.5 भवान् and त्वम् (*bhavān*, *tvam*) — “you,” respectful and familiar

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

त्वम् (*tvam*, familiar “you”) is from PIE *tū — the ancestor of English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, Hindi *tū*. भवान् (*bhavān*, respectful) is really a third-person honorific, “your honour” (from *bhavat*), and so takes a *third-person* verb.

Grammar Lens

Politeness by grammatical person. Where Hindi makes respect *plural* (*āp ...hain*), Sanskrit makes it *third-person*: you address someone as though speaking *about* them — “is your honour well?”

2.6 किम् (*kim*) — “what,” root of many question-words

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

किम् (*kim*, “what”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE *k^wo- — the ancestor of English **what**, **who**, Latin *quis*, and Hindi *kyā*. Sanskrit’s own questions all grow from this *ka-*: *kim* (what), *kaḥ* (who), *kadā* (when), *kutra* (where), *katham* (how) — the single seed of both Europe’s *qu-/wh-* and India’s *k-* words.

2.7 तव नाम किम्? — “what’s your name?”

तव (*tava*, “your,” genitive of *tvam*) + नाम (name) + किम् (what) = “your name what?” Here Sanskrit often drops *asti*. Respectfully: भवतः नाम किम्? (*bhavataḥ nāma kim?*). Note *mama* / *tava* / *bhavataḥ* — “my / your / your-honour’s,” all genitives.

2.8 आनन्दः (*ānandaḥ*) — “joy,” and “a joy to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

To say “pleased to meet you,” Sanskrit can say भवन्तं दृष्ट्वा आनन्दः (*bha-vantaṃ dr̥ṣṭvā ānandaḥ*) — “seeing you, [there is] joy.” आनन्दः (*ānandaḥ*, “joy, bliss”) is *ā-* (“fully”) + नन्द् (*nand*, “to rejoice”) — the *ānanda* of *sat-cit-ānanda* (“being-consciousness-bliss”) and the name **Ānanda**, the Buddha’s disciple. A simple greeting reaches for the word Indian thought uses for the deepest happiness.

2.9 The whole exchange

Sanskrit	English
मम नाम मीरा अस्ति।	My name is Mira.
तव नाम किम्?	What’s your name?
मम नाम अरुणः अस्ति।	My name is Arun.
भवन्तं दृष्ट्वा आनन्दः।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom is a *source*: *nāma* ($\rightarrow$ *name*), *mama* ($\rightarrow$ *my*), *asti* ($\rightarrow$ *is*), *kim* ($\rightarrow$ *what*). And Sanskrit keeps the copula its Dravidian neighbours drop. Next chapter: *bhavān katham asti?* (“how are you?”).

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — carried by the copula whose forms fathered English *am* and *is*:

भवान् कथम् अस्ति? (*bhavān katham asti* — “How are you?”)
अहं कुशली अस्मि, धन्यवादः। (*ahaṃ kuśalī asmi, dhanyavādah* — “I am well,
thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/SA-C03-.md.*

3.1 कथम् (*katham*) — “how,” another of the ka-questions

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कथम् (*katham*, “how”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. It heads the same *ka-* family (*kim*, *kaḥ*, *kadā*, *kutra*, *katham*), and gives the noun *kathā* (“a telling, a story”) and, worn down, Hindi’s *kaise*.

3.2 भवान् कथम् अस्ति? — “how are you?”

भवान् (*bhavān*, respectful “you”) + कथम् (how) + अस्ति (is) = “your honour how is?” Recall that *bhavān* (“your honour”) takes a **third-person** verb — so *asti* (“is”), not “are.” Familiar: त्वं कथम् अस्ति? (*tvam katham asi?*).

Grammar Lens

The copula, three persons: अस्मि (*asmi*, “I am”), असि (*asi*, “you are”), अस्ति (*asti*, “is”) — ancestors of English **am** and (via Latin/Greek) *is/est*. “How are you?” asks after a *state*, and Sanskrit always kept a verb for it.

3.3 अहम् (*aham*) — “I,” the ancestor of *ego* and *I***The word, taken apart — its roots and family**

अहम् (*aham*, “I”) is from PIE *h₁eǵ(H)om — the ancestor of Latin **ego**, Greek *egō*, and, worn all the way down, English **I**. Sanskrit *aham*, Latin *ego*, English *I* are one word across time. Its possessive is *mama* (“my”); curiously, “I” and “my” come from *different* roots (*eǵ- and *me-) — a quirk Sanskrit shares with English (*I* vs. *my*).

3.4 कुशलम् (*kuśalam*) — “well-being,” and how to answer**The word, taken apart — its roots and family**

कुशलम् (*kuśalam*, “well-being, welfare”) is native Sanskrit, famously from कुश (*kuśa*, the sacred grass) + a root of “cutting”: first “skilled [at gathering *kuśa* properly],” hence “adept, fit, in good order,” hence “well.” The reply: अहं कुशली अस्मि (*aham kuśalī asmi*), “I am well.”

3.5 न चिन्ता (*na cintā*) — “no worry”**The word, taken apart — its roots and family**

न चिन्ता literally “[there is] **no** worry” — न (*na*, “not,” from Chapter 1) + चिन्ता (*cintā*, “anxious thought,” from the root *cint* “to think”). Used for “never mind / you’re welcome.” *Na* is the ancient negative, PIE *ne, behind English **no**, **not**, Latin *nōn*; *cintā* is the same worry borrowed into Hindi (*cintā mat karo*). “Think nothing of it.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Sanskrit	English
भवान् कथम् अस्ति?	How are you?
अहं कुशली अस्मि, धन्यवादः।	I am well, thank you.
न चिन्ता।	No worry / you're welcome.

The taproot, both ways: *katham* (*ka-*, → English *how*), *aham* (→ Latin *ego*, English *I*), the copula *asmi* / *asti* (→ *am* / *is*), and *na* (→ *no*, Latin *nōn*). Next chapter: the farewells.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Sanskrit has no casual “bye.” Like its daughters, it takes leave by “I go” — and promises a seeing to come:

पुनर्दर्शनाय। (punar-darśanāya — “Until we meet again.”)

Practice lessons: *lessons/SA-C04-*.md*.

4.1 गच्छामि (*gacchāmi*) — “I go” (taking leave)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गच्छामि (*gacchāmi*, “I go”) is from the root गम् (*gam*, “to go”) — the root inside Chapter 1’s स्वागतम् (*svāgatam* = *su* + *āgata*, “well come”). That root is PIE *g^wem-, the ancestor of English **come**. To leave politely one says *gacchāmi* (“I go”) or *āgacchāmi* (“I shall come [back]”) — the “promise of return” the modern languages kept.

4.2 पुनः (*punaḥ*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पुनः (*punaḥ*, “again, once more”) is a native adverb (combining form *punar-*, as in *punar-janma*, “rebirth”). No single English cognate, but its work is shared: it turns a parting into “see you *again*.”

4.3 पुनर्दर्शनाय (*punar-darśanāya*) — “until we meet again”

पुनर् (*punar*, “again”) + दर्शनाय (*darśanāya*, “for seeing”) = “for seeing [you] again.” The word दर्शन (*darśana*, “seeing, vision”) is deep: the *darśan* one takes of a deity, and the name of the six *darśanas*, the schools of Indian philosophy (“ways of seeing”). This farewell promises a *beholding* to come.

Grammar Lens

The dative “for the sake of.” The ending -आय (-*āya*) is the dative singular — “to / for.” *Darśana* (a seeing) → *darśanāya* (for a seeing). Your first case.

4.4 श्वः (*śvaḥ*) — “tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

श्वः (*śvaḥ*, “tomorrow”) is from PIE *kes-. Where the modern languages muddle “tomorrow” and “yesterday” into one word (Hindi *kal*, Bengali *kāl*, from *kāla* “time”), classical Sanskrit kept them *separate*: *śvaḥ* is “tomorrow,” *hyaḥ* is “yesterday.” “See you tomorrow” is श्वः पुनर्दर्शनम् (*śvaḥ punar-darśanam*).

Grammar Lens

That the daughters blurred *śvaḥ* / *hyaḥ* into a single *kal* is a window into language change: the modern tongues traded precision for economy, letting tense carry the load.

4.5 The farewells

Sanskrit	English
गच्छामि।	I go. (taking leave)
पुनर्दर्शनाय।	Until we meet again.
श्वः पुनर्दर्शनम्।	See you tomorrow.

Roots banked: *gam* “to go” (→ English **come**), *punah* “again” (→ *punar-janma*), *darśana* “a beholding,” and *śvaḥ* / *hyaḥ* — “tomorrow” / “yester-

day,” kept apart. Next chapter: the first real verbs — and Sanskrit’s count to *three*.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and the most famous feature of the Sanskrit verb: it counts to **three**.

अहं संस्कृतं वदामि। (*ahaṃ saṃskṛtaṃ vadāmi* — “I speak Sanskrit.”)

Practice lessons: *lessons/SA-C05-*.md*.

5.1 वदामि (*vadāmi*) — “I speak,” and the Sanskrit verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

वदामि (*vadāmi*, “I speak”) is from the root वद् (*vad*, “to speak”) — the root of वाद (*vāda*, “a saying”) inside Chapter 1’s धन्यवादः (*dhanyavādaḥ*). The present is stem + ending: *vad-ā-mi*, where *-mi* means “I” (the same *-mi* as in *asmi*, “I am”).

Grammar Lens

Singular, dual, plural. Where English and Hindi count in two, Sanskrit counts in **three**, with a **dual** for exactly two:

number	form	meaning
singular	<i>vadāmi</i>	I speak
dual	<i>vadāvaḥ</i>	we two speak
plural	<i>vadāmaḥ</i>	we (three or more) speak

A whole number just for pairs — two eyes, two hands, a couple. Greek had it and lost it; English never kept it; Sanskrit polished it.

5.2 अहं संस्कृतं वदामि — “I speak Sanskrit”

अहम् (I) + संस्कृतम् (the object) + वदामि (speak) — “I Sanskrit speak,” verb last. The name संस्कृत (saṃskṛta) means “**put together, perfected**” — सम् (sam-, “together,” cousin of English *same*, Greek *syn-*) + कृत (kṛta, “made,” from *kr*). Named in contrast to *prākṛta* (“natural, raw” — Prakrit, the everyday speech from which Hindi, Bengali, and the rest descend).

Grammar Lens

Sandhi joins the words. *aham* + *saṃskṛtam* runs together as *ahaṃ saṃskṛtam* — the *m* softening to the anusvāra. That is *sandhi*, met in Chapter 1’s *svāgatam*; it is why Sanskrit flows.

5.3 वसामि (*vasāmi*) — “I live, I dwell”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

वसामि (*vasāmi*, “I dwell, live”) is from the root वस् (*vas*, “to dwell”), PIE *wes- — the ancestor of English **was** and **were** (the past of “to be” began as “to dwell/remain”). From *vas* come *vāsa* (“a dwelling”), *nivāsa* (“a residence”), *Vārāṇasī*. “I live in the city” is अहं नगरे वसामि (*ahaṃ nagare vasāmi*).

Grammar Lens

“In” is a case-ending. नगरे (*nagare*, “in the city”) = *nagara* in the **locative** (-e, “in/at”). Sanskrit has no separate word for “in” — it is folded into the noun’s ending, the ancestor of Hindi’s and Bengali’s postpositions.

5.4 करोमि (*karomi*) — “I do,” from the root behind *karma*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करोमि (*karomi*, “I do, make”) is from the root कृ (*kr*, “to do”), PIE *k^wer- — the root at the heart of this course: *namaskāraḥ* (“the *making* of a bow”), *karma* (“a thing *done*”), *saṃskṛta* (“*put together*”). “I work” is कार्यं करोमि (*kāryaṃ karomi*) — and कार्यम् (*kāryam*, “work”) is *itself* from *kr*. So “I work” is, at root, “*kr*-thing I *kr*-do.” Hindi’s *kām karnā* and Bengali’s *kāj karā* are its worn-down grandchildren.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Sanskrit	English
अहं संस्कृतं वदामि।	I speak Sanskrit.
अहं नगरे वसामि।	I live in the city.
अहं कार्यं करोमि।	I work.
वदावः।	We two speak. (the dual)

Three verbs, one engine (the *-mi* “I”), the verb always last, “in” folded into a case-ending — and a whole number, the **dual**, for exactly two. Roots banked: *vad* (speak → *dhanyavāda*), *vas* (dwell → English **was**), *kr* (do → *namaskāra*, *karma*, *saṃskṛta*). From here, Sanskrit — the source these tracks all point back to — only opens further.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Sanskrit numerals एक to पञ्च with their dual and gendered forms, and follow पञ्च outward into Punjab, pentagon, and the disputed history of punch.

Trace pañca out of Sanskrit: into Persian panj-āb, the five waters behind Punjab; into Greek pente in pentagon and pentathlon; and into punch, with the five-ingredients account labelled as common rather than settled.

6.1 एक, द्व, त्रि, चतुर, पञ्च — one to five

This chapter does something the other Indic chapters can't do alone. Sanskrit preserves the **Old Indo-Aryan forms behind** the Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati and Punjabi ones — and, at the same time, these forms are **cousins** of the English ones. Learn five and you get a foothold in both directions.

You'll want to know: the five

	stem	masculine	neuter
1	éka-	एकः ékaḥ	एकम् ékam
2	dvá-	द्वौ dváu	द्वे dvé
3	tri-	त्रयः trayaḥ	त्रीणि trīṇi
4	catúr-	चत्वारः catvāraḥ	चत्वारि catvāri
5	पञ्च pāñca	—	—

Three notes, and the third one matters more than it looks.

Sanskrit has a dual — a separate number for exactly two things — which is why “two” is *dváu* rather than a plural.

***Pañca* barely inflects in the nominative and accusative. It is also the one you already half-know.**

And Sanskrit numbers have gender. Look at the last column. When you meet these words again in Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati or Punjabi, they will mostly descend from the **neuter** forms — *trīṇi* and *catvāri*, not *trāyaḥ* and *catvāraḥ*. Keep that column in view; the daughter lessons depend on it.

What you’ve built: two directions

These five forms point in two directions. The next lesson lines them up with Latin and English and explains the sound laws. A final short lesson follows *pañca* into *Punjab*, *pentagon*, and the qualified history of *punch*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca”
- the exactly-two category — dual
- the daughter-language column — neuter

Before you move on

Give one to five in Sanskrit. (*Eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca*.) Why does “two” look unusual? (Sanskrit has a **dual** — a form for exactly two.) Which column will the modern languages mostly descend from? (**The neuter** — *trīṇi, catvāri*.) Which number barely changes across gender in this table? (*Pañca*.) Next: connect the Sanskrit forms west to Latin and English.

6.2 The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins

Give the five stems: *eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca*.

What you’ve built: one family, not borrowing

Sanskrit	Latin	English
<i>éka-</i>	<i>ūnus</i>	one
<i>dvá-</i>	<i>duo</i>	two
<i>tri-</i>	<i>trēs</i>	three
<i>catúr-</i>	<i>quattuor</i>	four
<i>pāñca</i>	<i>quīnque</i>	five

Sanskrit, Latin, and English inherited these from one family. Numbers resist replacement, so their relationship remains audible after millennia. The first row needs one caveat: *éka-* and *ūnus/one* use the same root with different suffixes, PIE **oy-ko-* versus **óynos*. They are relatives rather than the same complete word. The other four rows continue the same word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

PIE **k^w* was a *k* with rounded lips. In **k^wetwóres* “four,” three branches treated it differently:

branch	outcome	example
Latin	kept <i>qu-</i>	<i>quattuor</i>
Indo-Iranian	merged it with <i>k</i> , then palatalised before front vowels	<i>catvāri</i>
Germanic	shifted it to <i>hw-</i>	<i>what, who</i>

Sanskrit *c-* is therefore a regular result, not a random replacement. The same sequence helps explain *pañca*’s *ñc*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **f**- of *five* does not come from **k^w*. It comes from initial **p*, changed to *f* by **Grimm’s law**, as in *pater* → *father* and *pēs* → *foot*.

English *four* is irregular. By the sound rule it should begin *hw-* like *what*. Its *f-* is usually explained as analogy with neighbouring *five*. Counting words can reshape one another.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tri*, *trēs*, *three*
- rounded *k* — *quattuor*, *catvāri*, *what*
- initial *p* → *f* — *pañca*/*five*
- regular inheritance or borrowing — inheritance

Before you move on

Are the Latin and Sanskrit forms borrowed from one another? (No: they are inherited cousins.) What are the three outcomes of $*k^w$? (Latin *qu-*, Indo-Iranian *c-* after merger and palatalisation, Germanic *hw-*.) Where does *five*'s initial *f* come from? (PIE *p* by Grimm's law.) What is the usual explanation for *four* also beginning with *f*? (Analogy with neighbouring *five*.)

6.3 *Pañca* hiding in familiar words

Say Sanskrit “five.” (*Pañca*.) Give its English cousin. (*Five*.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Punjab comes from Persian *pañj-āb*, “five waters,” for the land of five rivers spanning India and Pakistan. Persian *pañj* is the Iranian cousin of Indic *pañca*: both descend from the same Indo-Iranian and PIE number root.

The place-name is Persian, not Sanskrit, but the family resemblance is real.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Greek **pente** is another descendant of the same root. It appears in **pentagon**, a five-sided figure, and **pentathlon**, a five-event contest.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The usual account derives **punch**, the drink, from Hindi *pāñich* ← Sanskrit *pañca*, because the drink was said to contain five ingredients.

That origin is not unanimous. A rival derives the word from **puncheon**, a type of cask. Keep the useful connection with a label: “the common five-ingredients account,” not an unquestioned fact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pañ* + *āb* — five waters
- Greek *pente* — pentagon, pentathlon
- *punch* — common account, not certain

Before you move on

What does *Punjab* mean? (“Five waters.”) Is Persian *pañ* borrowed from Sanskrit? (No: it is an Iranian cousin.) Which Greek form hides in *pentagon*? (*Pente*.) What caution belongs with the drink *punch*? (The five-ingredients derivation is common, but *puncheon* is a rival account.)

Chapter 7

The Core Verbs

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone is, becomes, goes, comes, eats, sees and knows in Sanskrit; I can name each verb by its dhātu rather than by its present form, say which of the three gaṇa patterns builds its stem, and point at the English word that descends from the same root.

Say जानाति, name its root ज्ञा and the syllable -ना- its class plants inside the word, run back through the chapter’s six verbs as root plus class plus ending, separate the one that is a prefixed form of another, and pair गम्, अद्, पश् and भू with come, eat, inspect and be.

7.1 अस्ति and भवति — Sanskrit’s two words for “is”

Six chapters of words. Now the machinery. A Sanskrit verb is never quoted the way an English one is, and this pair shows why.

You’ll want to know: अस्ति and भवति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
अस्ति	<i>asti</i>	he, she, or it is
भवति	<i>bhavati</i>	he, she, or it becomes

Both land in English as “is.” *Asti* states that something simply **is** there. *Bhavati* says something **comes to be** — a state arriving rather than sitting still. Sanskrit never merged the two.

The letters in this word

अ is *a*, a short neutral vowel; ति is *tī*. Inside अस्ति the *s* and *t* stack into one joined shape, स्ति — Devanagari fuses a consonant cluster into a single letter. भवति needs no fusing: भ *bha*, व *va*, ति *tī*.

Grammar Lens: the dhātu and its gaṇa

Sanskrit files a verb under its धातु (*dhātu*), its **root** — the bare syllable a dictionary lists. *Asti* is filed under अस् (*as*), *bhavati* under भू (*bhū*). A root is not yet a word. To reach the present it joins one of ten गण (*gaṇa*) classes, and the class decides what happens between root and ending. Class 2 adds nothing: *as* + *tī* → *asti*. Class 1 strengthens the root and adds a vowel: *bhū* → *bhava* + *tī* → *bhavati*. Root, then class, then ending. Every verb in this chapter is built that way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अस् is PIE **es-*: English **is**, Latin *est*, German *ist*, barely worn. भू is PIE **bheu-*, “to grow, to come to be”: English **be** and **been**, Latin *futūrus* behind **future**, Greek *phusis* behind **physics**. Now the surprise. English “to be” is stitched from *both* — *am*, *is*, *are* from **es-*; *be*, *been*, *being* from **bheu-*. English fused two verbs into one ragged paradigm. Sanskrit left them side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*asti*” — it is
- “*bhavati*” — it becomes
- the two roots — *as*, *bhū*
- the English halves — “is” from one, “been” from the other

Before you move on

Which two roots stand behind *asti* and *bhavati*? (अस् *as* and भू *bhū*.)
What does a गण class do? (**Turns a root into a present stem** —

nothing added for *as*, a vowel added for *bhū*.) Which English words descend from each? (*Is* from *as*; *be* and *been* from *bhū*.) Next: a root whose present stem you could never have guessed.

7.2 गच्छति (gacchati) — “goes,” and why dictionaries file it elsewhere

Root, then class, then ending. Say the two roots from last time. (*As*, *bhū*.) Here the middle step stops being tidy.

You’ll want to know: गच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	he, she, or it goes
गच्छामि	<i>gacchāmi</i>	I go

The second form is already yours: Chapter 4 used it to take leave. Same stem, different ending — -ति *-ti* for “he, she, it,” -मि *-āmi* for “I.”

The letters in this word

ग is *ga*. ति is *ti*, already familiar. Between them sits च्छ, a doubled *ch* — one stacked shape for two *ch* sounds in a row, held slightly long: *gach-cha*. Let the middle of the word linger.

Grammar Lens: the stem that hides its root

The root here is गम् (*gam*), “to go.” The present stem is गच्छ (*gaccha*). No rule you have met turns one into the other, and no amount of staring at *gaccha* recovers *gam*.

That is the whole reason Sanskrit hangs its grammar on the root rather than on any spoken form. *Gam* is where the dictionary keeps this verb, where its past and future are built from, and where its relatives — गति *gati* “motion,” आगम *āgama* “arrival” — are visibly cousins. Learn roots, not forms.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गम् is PIE **gwem-*. Its English descendant is **come** — the same root, turned around: what one language walks away with, another walks toward.

Latin took it as *venīre*, “to come,” and English then borrowed it back in a crowd: **venue**, **convene**, **intervene**, **advent**, **adventure**. Sanskrit *gacchati* and English *come* are the two ends of one very old word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati” — it goes
- “gacchāmi” — I go
- the root, not the stem — *gam*
- the English cousin — *come*

Before you move on

What is the root of *gacchati*? (गम् *gam*.) Could you have predicted the stem from it? (**No** — which is why the root is what gets learned.) Which ending makes it “I go”? (-āmi *-āmi*.) Which English verb is the same root? (**Come**.) Next: the same stem, aimed the other way.

7.3 आगच्छति (āgacchati) — “comes,” or “goes” reversed

Say “it goes.” (*Gacchati*.) Now add one syllable in front and the direction reverses.

You’ll want to know: आगच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	it goes
आगच्छति	<i>āgacchati</i>	it comes

आ (ā) means “toward, hither.” Stick it on the front and the motion turns back to face you. Sanskrit has no separate word for “come” at all: coming is going, aimed homeward.

The letters in this word

Everything after the first letter is last lesson’s word, unchanged. The new piece is आ, the long ā — the same vowel as अ a but held roughly twice as long. Length alone carries meaning in Sanskrit, so give it its time: *aa-gach-cha-ti*.

Grammar Lens: the upasarga, Sanskrit’s aiming device

आ is an उपसर्ग (*upasarga*), a preverb. Sanskrit has about twenty, and any of them may ride in front of a root to re-aim it:

prefix	sense	on गम्
आ ā	toward	āgacchati, comes
सम् sam	together	samigacchati, goes together
नि ni	down	nigacchati, goes down

A handful of roots plus a handful of prefixes covers an enormous amount of vocabulary. You have met the trick already without being told: संस्कृत (*saṃskṛta*, “Sanskrit”) is *sam* “together” on the root कृ *kr* “make” — put-together, and so perfected.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Latin aims *venīre* “come” with the same kind of prefix: *ad-* “toward” gives **advent**, *con-* “with” gives **convene**, *inter-* “between” gives **intervene**. English does it natively too — *come* becomes **become**, **overcome**, **income**.

Sanskrit simply runs the system harder and more openly, with the seams left visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati ... āgacchati” — goes, comes
- the prefix and its sense — ā, toward

- one more prefix on the same root — *sam*, together

Before you move on

How does Sanskrit say “comes”? (आगच्छति — *ā* “toward” on “goes.”)
 What is such a prefix called? (An उपसर्ग, *upasarga*.) Which Sanskrit
 word you already knew is built the same way? (संस्कृत — *sam* plus *kṛ*.)
 Next: a verb whose everyday form is not the one related to English.

7.4 खादति (khādati) — “eats,” and the cousin it is not

Name the three steps that build a Sanskrit present. (**Root, class, ending**.) This verb is the tidiest one yet — and hides a warning.

You’ll want to know: खादति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
खादति	<i>khādati</i>	he, she, or it eats
खाद्य	<i>khādyā</i>	edible , food

The root is खाद् (*khād*), and it belongs to the same class 1 as *bhū*, so the build is plain: *khād* + *a* + *ti* → *khādati*. No stacked letters, no surprises, nothing hidden.

The letters in this word

खा is *khā*: a *k* with a puff of breath after it, then the long *ā* you met last lesson. Sanskrit treats that puff as a separate letter, not an accent — क *ka* and ख *kha* are two different letters that change meaning. द is *da*, ति is *ti*.

Grammar Lens: the everyday word and the related word

English **eat**, Latin *edere* (behind **edible**), and German *essen* all descend from PIE **ed-*. Sanskrit inherited it too, as the root अद् (*ad*), class 2 — endings straight onto the root, like *asti*: *ad* + *ti* → अस्ति (*atti*), “eats.” But *atti* is not the ordinary word. Classical Sanskrit eats with खाद्, a root with no clear European relative at all.

So the family word and the everyday word part company here. Cognates tell you where a language came from; they do not promise to tell you what it says at dinner. Keep the two questions separate.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The pattern repeats across the family. English has native **eat** beside borrowed **consume** and **devour**; Sanskrit has inherited अद् beside ordinary खाद्.

A language keeps its old word somewhere — in a proverb, a compound, a sacred text — while daily speech moves on to another. *Khādyā*, “edible,” is the word you will actually meet on a menu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “khādati” — it eats
- the root and its class build — *khād ... a ... ti*
- the cousin of English *eat* — *ad, atti*

Before you move on

What is the ordinary Sanskrit verb for eating? (खादति, *khādati*, root खाद्.) Which Sanskrit root is the actual cousin of English *eat*? (अद् *ad*, giving *atti*.) Which class does *ad* belong to, and how do you know? (Class 2 — the ending goes straight onto the root, as in *asti*.) Next: a verb built out of two different roots.

7.5 पश्यति (paśyati) — “sees,” a verb with two roots

So far one root has built each verb. Here two roots share the work, and you have already met the quieter one.

You'll want to know: पश्यति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पश्यति	<i>paśyati</i>	he, she, or it sees
दर्शन	<i>darśana</i>	a beholding , a viewing

The present tense comes from the root पश् (paś). Every other tense of this verb comes from a different root, दृश् (dṛś) — and dṛś is where दर्शन was built, the word inside Chapter 4's farewell पुनर्दर्शनाय, “until a seeing again.”

Two roots, one verb, divided by tense. English does the same with *go* and *went*, which were never the same verb either.

The letters in this word

प is *pa*. Then श्य, a stack of two letters: श *śa*, a *sh* made with the tongue high and forward, plus य *ya*. Say them glued: *pash-ya-ti*. Sanskrit has three different *s* letters, and this is the one that leans toward *sh*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पश् descends from PIE **spek-*, “to observe closely.” The *s* and the *p* swapped places on the way into Indo-Iranian, which is why the Sanskrit form begins *paś-* rather than *spaś-*.

Latin kept it straight as *specere*, and English is full of the results: **spectacle**, **inspect**, **respect**, **species**, **suspect**, **spy**.

Greek swapped the letters too, in its own direction, giving *skop-*: **telescope**, **microscope**, **skeptic**, **bishop** (from *episkopos*, an overseer).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “paśyati” — it sees
- the two roots — *paś* for the present, *dṛś* for the rest
- the Chapter 4 word from the other root — *darśana*
- the English descendants — *inspect*, *species*, *telescope*

Before you move on

Which root gives the present *paśyati*? (पश् *paś*.) Which root supplies the rest of the verb? (दृश् *drś* — the one behind *darśana*.) What PIE root is *paś* from? (**Spek-*.) Name two English words from it. (**Inspect**, **species**, **telescope** — any two.) Next: the verb that means “know,” and the class that plants a syllable in the middle.

7.6 जानाति (jānāti) — “knows,” and English *know* is the same word

Two ways a root has become a stem so far: nothing added, or a vowel added. Here is the third, and it is the boldest.

You’ll want to know: जानाति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
जानाति	<i>jānāti</i>	he, she, or it knows
ज्ञान	<i>jñāna</i>	knowledge

The root is ज्ञा (*jñā*). Its class, the ninth, does not add a vowel at the end — it plants a whole syllable -ना- (-*nā*-) between root and ending: *jā* + *nā* + *ti* → *jānāti*. The marker sits inside the word.

The letters in this word

ज्ञा is *jā*; ना *nā* and ति *ti* close it. The root’s own spelling ज्ञ is a famous stacked letter, *j* over *ñ*, said *gya* across much of India today and *jñā* in the classical description. Pick one and stay with it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ज्ञा is PIE **gno-*. English **know** is that root undisguised, and so are **can** and **cunning**, which began as “know how.”

Latin took it as *noscere*: **notice**, **notion**, **cognition**, **ignore** (“not-know”), **noble** (“well-known”). Greek took it as *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**.

One root, a whole shelf of English vocabulary, and Sanskrit ज्ञान *jñāna* sitting at the other end of it.

What you've built: six verbs, three ways to build a stem

Asti, bhavati, gacchati, āgacchati, khādati, paśyati, jñāti. Every one is a root plus a class plus an ending, and the class was the only thing that varied: nothing inserted (*as-ti*), a vowel appended (*bhava-ti, khāda-ti*), or a syllable planted inside (*jñā-nā-ti*). Prefix one and you aim it: *ā-gacchati*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jñāti” — it knows
- the root and its planted syllable — *jñā ... nā*
- the English twin — *know*
- three roots and their English kin — *gam/come, ad/eat, paś/inspect*

Before you move on

What is the root of *jñāti*, and what does its class insert? (ज्ञा *jñā*; the syllable -ना-.) Give the six verbs of this chapter. (*Asti, gacchati, āgacchati, khādati, paśyati, jñāti*.) Which two are one root plus a prefix? (गच्छति and आगच्छति.) Which Sanskrit root is English *know*? (ज्ञा.) And which English words carry *gam, ad, paś*, and *bhū*? (*Come, eat, inspect, be* — four roots you now own in two languages.)

The Devanagari script and Sanskrit sounds — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system, with the points a Devanagari reader still needs for *Sanskrit*.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** क *ka*, न *na*, म *ma* — left to right under a connecting top line.
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** का *kā*, कि *ki*, की *kī*, कु *ku*, के *ke*, को *ko*. A standalone (word-initial) vowel has its own letter: अ *a*, आ *ā*, इ *i*...
3. **A halant removes the vowel**, and the bare consonant joins the next as a **conjunct**: स् + त → स्त, न + य → न्य.

What Sanskrit needs even from a Devanagari reader

- **The visarga ृ (ḥ).** A soft breathed echo of the preceding vowel at a word’s end — *namaskārah*, *rāmah*. It usually marks the masculine-singular ending, so it is grammatical as well as phonetic.
- **The anusvāra ँ (ṁ/ṅ).** A dot above the line nasalising the vowel or standing for a nasal consonant before another — very frequent in Sanskrit.
- **The vocalic ण ॠ (as in ṛgveda, “Rg Veda”).** Sanskrit treats ण as a *vowel* — it is the ण of *māṭṛ* “mother” and *pitr* “father,” the words that proved Sanskrit’s kinship with Latin *māter/pater* and English *mother/father*.

- **Sandhi.** Sanskrit fuses words at their seams by fixed sound-rules: *su* + *āgata* → *svāgata*. The lessons flag each fusion where it happens.

Sanskrit in the family

Sanskrit is the classical language of India — the tongue of the Vedas, of Kālidāsa, of Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain learning — and the ancestor of the modern Indo-Aryan languages (Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, Bengali, and more). It is a senior branch of **Indo-European**, sister to Greek, Latin, and the Germanic languages including English. That is why this curriculum treats it, with Latin, as a *taproot*: its words reach both east into South Asia and west into Europe, and the lessons trace both directions.